



Costume Design Guild

Ancient to folk and cultures

Different time periods

Week 4

My master research

- Fashion designer > master game technologies
- Running these guilds as part of my master research
- Needs to be recorded for documentation
- Your input is my data
- Helps me graduate ☺
- In turn: Ask me for help, feedback etc on your costume work!

Image of my bachelor graduation work



To introduce myself quickly, I am Imara, my previous study was fashion design and I am now doing my master in game technologies.

I've started running these guilds as part of my master research, and it's about figuring out which costume design principles are important for video game design, and I will find this out by observing how you guys interact with and react to the guild content I have prepared for you guys

Your input, thoughts, reflections, work you show me if all part of the data I'm gathering. Your input will help me graduate
And in turn I am always available if you need help, feedback or anything else.

Agenda

1. Period & game examples
2. Silhouette & key garments
3. Social hierarchy
4. Materials, textiles & dyes
5. Construction & details
6. Special topics
7. Discussion & reflection

Acknowledgement: A lot of ground to cover, going wide instead of deep



The agenda is the same as last guilds, but theres a lot of ground to cover today, it's a lot broader than the previous ones and ill be going wide instead of deep across these very different cultures in space and time.

So im really sorry if this is a huge amount of information and might go a bit too fast at times. The presentation is uploaded to teams so you can always look at it in your own pace again

Question for you

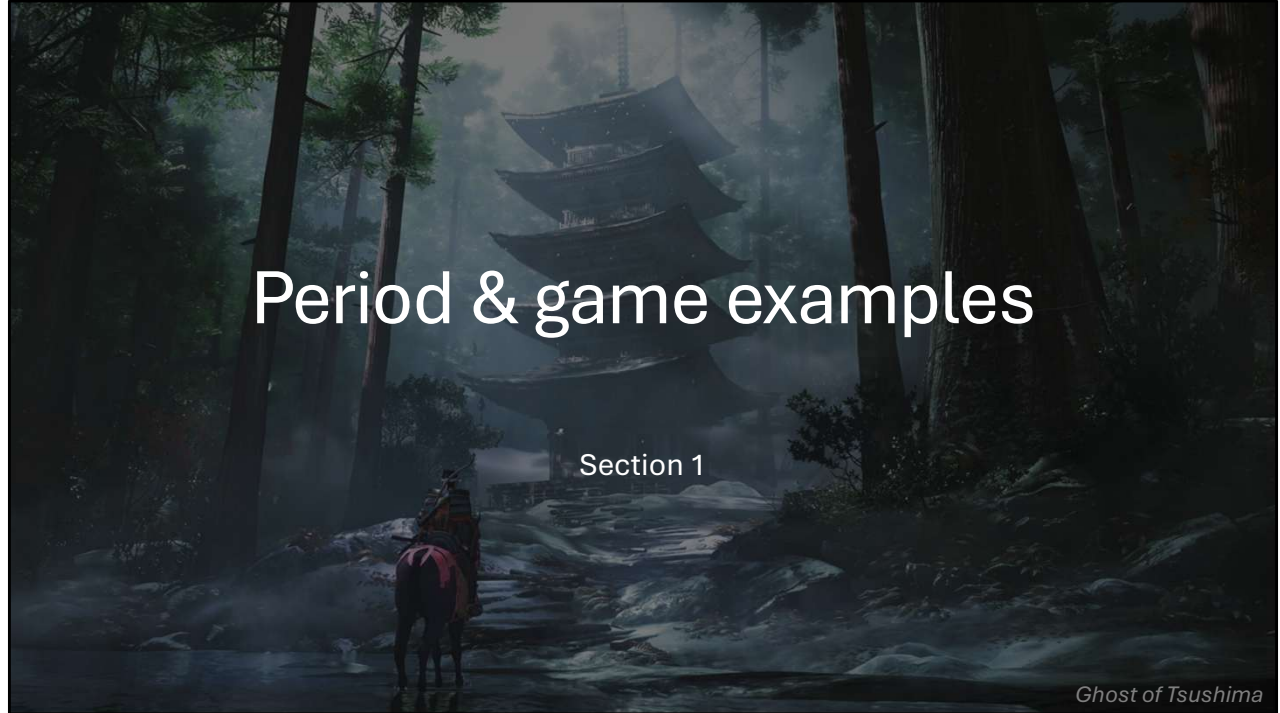
Can you name a game with ancient civilizations, non-European cultures, or tribal settings?

What **visual elements** made you recognise that culture or period?

I already have a question for you, Can you name a game with ancient civilizations, non-European cultures, or tribal settings?

What **visual elements** made you recognise that culture or period?

Thank you for your answers, the visual recognition is what this session will be about.



Lets start with period and game examples

Introduction

- Breaking Western medieval default
- Cultural representation - Non-European design principles
- **Construction diversity** - Stone Age to sophisticated ancient civilizations
- Different material relationships - what was available shaped what was possible



A lot of games are based on the western medieval default but there is so much more than just that to take inspiration from.

Today is about expanding that by looking into cultural representation, construction diversity and how different material availability shaped what was possible

Period explanation

This session will cover:

- Survival/primal
 - Indigenous, tribal, stone-age
- Northern Europe
 - Norse, Viking
- Wrapped/draped
 - Greece, Egypt, Rome
- Asian
 - Japan, China



This session will cover a range of subjects so we'll start with survival and primal based cultures, then move to northern Europe with the Norse and Vikings. When we move to wrapped and draped cultures like Greece, Egypt, and Rome. And lastly a bit of the Asian cultures like Japan and China.

Game examples



^ Stone age/ primal



^ Ancient civilisations



^ Asian medieval/renaissance



^ Vikings/norse

Here are some games that can be divided in these four period and cultures. You might've played some of them.

Stone Age/Tribal: Far Cry Primal (10,000 BCE), Horizon franchise (tribal construction)

Ancient Civilizations: AC Origins (Egypt), AC Odyssey (Greece), God of War (Greek/Norse mythl.)

Asian Medieval/Renaissance: Ghost of Tsushima (13th century Japan), AC Shadows (16th century Japan), Wo Long: Fallen Dynasty (Three Kingdoms China)

Vikings/Norse: AC Valhalla (9th century), God of War Ragnarök

Other Cultures: Various Far Cry entries (Himalayan, Pacific Island cultures)

Key take-aways

- Understanding how different cultures approach clothing construction:
 - = more authentic, interesting character designs
 - = makes you a more versatile game artist



This isn't about memorising historical facts. It's about having more tools in your head when you sit down to design.

So understanding how different cultures approach clothing construction will allow you to make more authentic and interesting character designs

And also make you a more versatile game artist

Question for you

Think about Greek togas, Japanese kimono, or Viking clothing

What shapes come to mind?

How are they different from medieval European tunics?

Let them answer before moving on.

The goal is to surface what they already think they know — which might be vague or stereotype-based — so the next section can either confirm or correct it.

That's a more engaging learning sequence than just presenting information cold.

Silhouette & key garments

Section 2



Defining silhouette

MINIMAL/SURVIVAL:

- **Stone Age** –
Animal skin wraps, bone/shell accessories
- **Tribal (Horizon-style)** –
Leather wraps, practical construction, found materials



Start with the simplest possible construction: you have an animal, you have its skin, you wear it.

No pattern, no sewing in the modern sense.

What's interesting here is that even at this level, there are design choices — what you tie, what you leave open, what you add for decoration.

Far Cry Primal and Horizon both interpret this differently.

Far cry leans on rough and crude, Horizon gives the tribal aesthetic a lot more intentional structure even though the materials logic is similar.

Defining silhouette

WRAPPED/DRAPED

(No sewing required):

- **Greek Chiton**
 - Rectangle draped and pinned, creates cascading folds
- **Roman Toga**
 - Semicircle wrap, status through draping complexity
- **Egyptian Shendyt**
 - Linen kilt, pleated or wrapped
- **Indian Sari**
 - Long wrap, endless variation



< Chiton



< Toga



< Shendyt



< Sari

The key thing for wrapped and draped garments is that none of these garments are sewn into shape.

They're rectangles and semicircles that become clothing through how they're arranged on the body.

It's a different design logic that the tailored clothing we saw from the Victorian period

Defining silhouette

TUNIC-BASED

(European but not Western):

- **Viking layered tunics**
 - Similar to medieval but earlier, more wrappings
- **Norse leg wrappings**
 - Practical for cold/wet



Viking clothing often gets lumped in with medieval European in game art, but it predates most of what people think of as "medieval" and the layering logic is different.

The leg wrappings especially is not just decoration, it's genuinely functional for cold and wet terrain.

If you're designing a Norse character, those wrappings tell a story about the climate without a single line of dialogue.

Defining silhouette

CROSS-COLLAR ROBES

(Asian construction):

- **Japanese Kimono**
 - T-shaped, flat pattern, wrapped left over right
- **Chinese Hanfu**
 - Flowing sleeves, cross-collar, layered
- **Korean Hanbok**
 - High waist, full skirt, jeogori top



< Kimono



^ Hanfu



< Hanbok

All these Asian defining silhouettes have one thing in common, they start out kind of large and rectangle shaped and the shaping comes from how its wrapped or belted and layered

Key silhouettes

- 1. Draped Roman**
 - Flowing, vertical folds, asymmetric draping
- 2. Wrapped Egyptian**
 - Pleated linen, geometric, exposed skin
- 3. T-shaped Asian robes**
 - Flat pattern, hanging sleeves, layered
- 4. Practical tribal**
 - Fitted wraps, exposed limbs for movement, natural materials



Here you can see the four very different silhouettes, all four have different construction philosophies.

This session is about helping you recognise the visual cues that make these garments recognisably from that period or culture

Visual recognition

- Asymmetric draping + vertical folds = Greek/Roman
- Cross-collar + hanging sleeves = Asian
- Animal pelts + bone accessories = tribal/ancient



This is a very distilled version of visual cues of each subject

Asymmetric draping with vertical folds reads Greek/Roman.

Cross-collar with hanging sleeves reads Asian.

Animal pelts and bone reads tribal.

You can use these visual shortcuts in your work, and by knowing where they come from will help you use them more deliberately rather than just copying a reference.

Question for you

Different cultures showed status in different ways.

Can you think of how ancient Egypt, feudal Japan, or tribal societies might have communicated hierarchy through costume.

Was it the same as medieval Europe?

I have another question for you, Different cultures showed status in different ways.

Can you think of how ancient Egypt, feudal Japan, or tribal societies might have communicated hierarchy through costume.

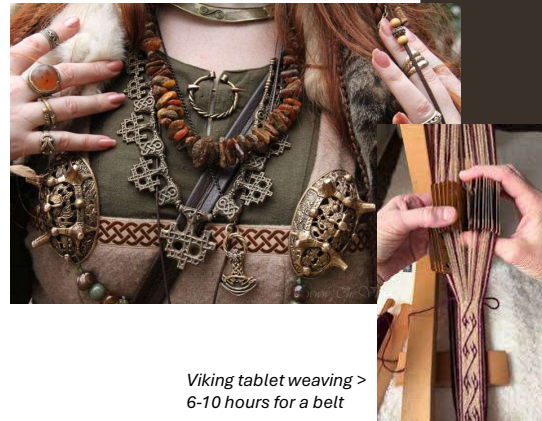
Was it the same as medieval Europe?

Spoiler: the mechanisms are different even though the underlying logic (wealth = visual complexity) is consistent across cultures. See if they pick up on that themselves.



Universal across cultures

1. **Material quality** always signals wealth
2. **Ornamentation density** = leisure time to create/acquire
3. **Colour intensity** = access to rare dyes
4. **Layering** = surplus resources
5. **Condition** = manual labour vs. not



*Viking tablet weaving >
6-10 hours for a belt*

These 5 principles apply across almost every culture in human history. And I think it's really interesting that people separated by thousands of miles and thousands of years keep coming to the same solutions for communicating status through clothing.

Material quality, ornamentation, colour, layering, condition.

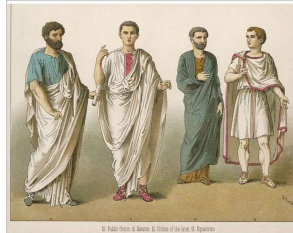
Viking tablet weaving is a good example of using time to create ornamentation: it takes six to ten hours for a belt.

Visual markers of status

ANCIENT GREECE:

GODS/HEROES → CITIZENS → METICS (FOREIGNERS) → SLAVES

- **Citizens:** Quality draped chiton, jewellery, elaborate pins
- **Slaves:** Simple, shorter chiton, minimal decoration
- **Warriors:** Bronze armour quality, helmet crests, shield decoration



Greek status is interesting because it's partly visible in the quality of the draping itself.

A well-draped chiton requires good fabric as cheap linen doesn't fall the same way.

So even without jewellery, the quality and amount of the drape tells you something.

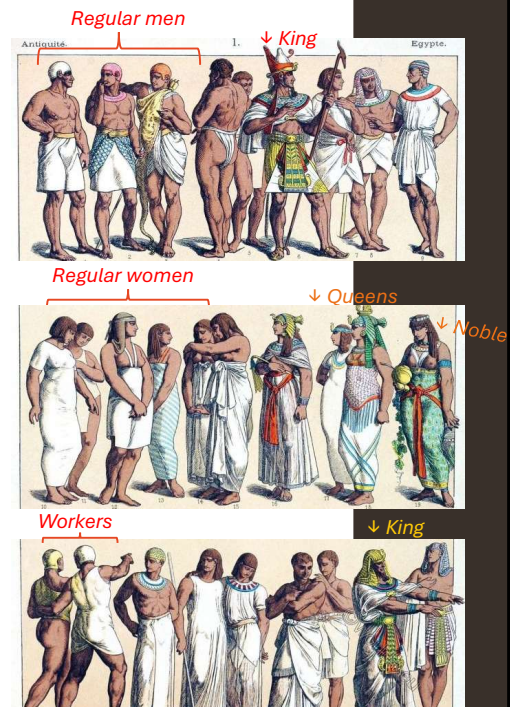
Warriors get a separate visual language through armour which told you who they belonged to or which rank they were

Visual markers of status

ANCIENT EGYPT:

PHARAOH/ROYAL → PRIESTS → NOBLES → SCRIBES → CRAFTSMEN → LABORERS

- **Royal:** Gold jewellery, finest linen (pleated), elaborate headdresses, makeup
- **Priests:** Leopard skin cloaks (specific to priests), white linen
- **Laborers:** Simple linen wraps, minimal jewellery, often shirtless
- **Jewellery volume = status** (gold, lapis lazuli, carnelian for rich; copper, shells for poor)



Egypt has one of the most legible hierarchy systems in ancient history.

The image on the slide shows the range from labourers in basic linen wraps to the pharaoh layered in gold and headdress.

Here again applies how nicer the drape, the nicer the fabric was.

Sorry if I go a little too fast to look at the pictures, I upload each presentation to the guild files so you can look at them as long as you want after this session

Visual markers of status

VIKING/NORSE:

JARLS (CHIEFS) → KARLS (FREEMEN) → THRALLS (SLAVES)

- **Jarl:** Fur quality (bear, wolf), imported fabrics, arm rings (wealth display), ornate brooches
- **Freeman:** Good wool, practical, some decoration
- **Thrall:** Rough cloth, no jewellery, basic

Jarl →



Thrall →



Freeman →



Fur quality is the main signal here.

Bear and wolf pelts were not decorative choices — they were expensive, dangerous to obtain, and everyone understood that.

The arm rings are also interesting: Viking wealth was literally worn on the body as rings of silver or gold.

A jarl with twelve arm rings versus a freeman with two and a thrall with none is an immediately legible status difference. No text needed.

Visual markers of status

FEUDAL JAPAN (SAMURAI ERA):

EMPEROR → SHOGUN → DAIMYO → SAMURAI →
PEASANTS → OUTCASTS

- **Samurai:** Armor quality (lacquer, silk cords), family crests (mon), swords (two = full samurai)
- **Commoners:** Simple, natural colours, practical, no weapons
 - Merchant, farmers, craftsmen
- Outcast



← Mino (straw cape)



In feudal Japan, all classes wore kimono, but they were made from the best fabric your class could afford.

For samurai The two swords are probably the most famous status marker in this hierarchy — only full samurai could carry both.

But the armour itself communicates rank too: lacquer quality, silk cord colours, they offer protection but are also a sign of status

The mino (straw cape) at the bottom of the slide is a nice contrast, worn completely for function and protection

You can place any character in this hierarchy just from those visual cues

Game design application

- **Greek God NPC?** Glowing, perfect draping, gold accents everywhere
- **Egyptian Pharaoh Boss?** Maximum gold, elaborate headdress, pristine linen
- **Samurai Commander?** Ornate armour, family crest prominent, quality silk
- **Tribal Chief?** Best furs, most feathers/bones, unique headdress
- **Generic villager?** Simple, practical, minimal decoration



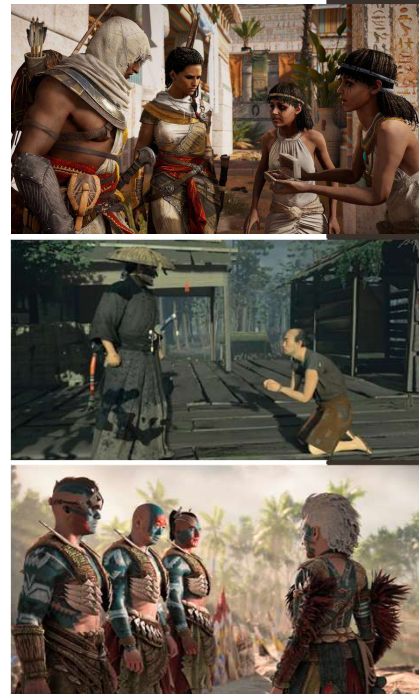
Here are some quick archetypes that could be useful when designing for these periods and cultures.

When designing a boss, go big on hierarchy signals. When designing a generic npc villager, go maximum on simplicity, minimal decoration and use practical materials.

Make the viewer or player read who matters, make the important characters visually complex but leave the filler characters simple

Game examples

- **AC Origins:** Clear Egyptian class distinction through jewellery and linen quality
- **Ghost of Tsushima:** Samurai armour vs. peasant clothing very distinct
- **Horizon:** Tribal leaders have more elaborate decoration, better materials



AC Origins is a good one to bring up if anyone's played it — the class distinction between characters is clear enough to read in motion, and Ghost of Tsushima does the same thing for Japan.

These are examples of games where the art team did the research and it shows.

Question for you

We've talked about wool and linen in medieval Europe.

What materials do you think ancient Egypt used?

What about Japan?

Does climate affect what fabrics cultures develop?

Time for another question for you to bridge to the next subject. We've talked about wool and linen in medieval Europe. But What materials do you think ancient Egypt used? And What about Japan? Do you think climate affects what fabrics cultures develop?

Answer: Climate shapes material availability, which shapes what cultures develop skill in, which shapes what clothing looks like. That's the chain we're about to unpack.



Materials, textiles & dyes

Section 4

Universal principles

Climate dictates material:

- Hot = lightweight, breathable (linen, cotton)
- Cold = insulation (wool, fur)
- Wet = water-resistant (treated leather, felted wool)

Local availability:

- Silk in Asia (abundant) vs. Europe (rare import)
- Linen in Egypt (flax grows well) vs. cold climates (difficult)

Technology level:

- Advanced weaving = finer fabrics
- Dye technology = colour range



The universal principles is that the three variables: climate, local availability and technology level influences every choice in material and fabrics.

Knowing the world you character will live in, will allow you to have a framework for making material decisions

Whether the world is based on history or speculative and fantasy, answering these three questions will get you to a believable material palate faster than just picking stuff that looks cool

Stone age / prehistoric

STONE AGE/PREHISTORIC:

Materials:

- **Animal skins** - Primary material
 - Leather, fur, hide
 - Sinew for sewing
- **Plant fibers** - Woven/twisted
 - Cordage, basic textiles

"Dyes":

- Earth pigments painted on
- Natural hide colors
- No true dyeing yet



The stone age used very basic and raw materials and didn't have dyes yet. The palette is extremely limited to natural hide colours and ochre red, the stuff they used to paint on cave walls.

If you would design a prehistoric character and gave them something bright blue, that's an instant red flag making it unbelievable as players don't expect that

Indigenous / tribal (various)

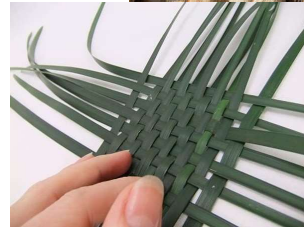
INDIGENOUS/TRIBAL (Various):

Materials by Region:

- **Animal skins** - Depends on local fauna
 - Deer, elk, buffalo (North America).
 - Treatment: Brain-tanning (soft), smoke-curing (water-resistant)
- **Plant fibers:** Tree bark cloth (tapa in Pacific)
 - Woven grasses (Africa).
 - Cotton (Americas - sophisticated weaving)
- **Fur, feathers** - Decoration and warmth

Dyes: - Highly regional

- Whatever plants/minerals available
- Ochres (earth pigments) - reds, yellows, browns
- Plant-based (varies by region)
- Some cultures: very limited palette, others: vibrant



< Grass weaving



Plant dye >

For the indigenous and tribal people, the variety in what is available in the regions is huge

Everything depends on location, so what materials, plants, animals and minerals are available

Some cultures were very limited in dye colours while others had a lot of dyestuffs to choose from.

Tribal doesn't easily flatten into one single visual language as you can see

Mediterranean (Greece, Rome, Egypt)

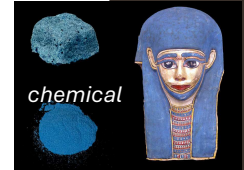
MEDITERRANEAN (Greece, Rome, Egypt):

Materials:

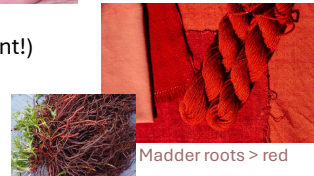
- **Linen** - THE fabric (warmer climates)
 - Egyptian linen = finest in world (thread count incredibly high). Pleats held through starch/moisture
 - White = wealth (hardest to keep clean)
- **Wool** - Greece/Rome (cooler regions)
 - Similar to medieval wool. Often left natural color

Dyes:

- **Tyrian Purple**: Same snail dye = same expense
- **Egyptian Blue**: Copper-based, synthetic (first synthetic pigment!)
- **Madder reds, woad blues** - Same plants, different regions
- **Saffron yellow** - Expensive, from crocus flowers



chemical
Heating silica, lime, copper and alkali > blue



Madder roots > red



Crocus flower > saffron yellow

The mediterranean cultures used linen a lot as it is very nice in warmer climates. And they used wool in the cooler regions. What I find interesting about the Egyptians is that they were already synthetically producing dye pigments thousands of years before we western people did it. That says something about how sophisticated their material culture really was

Northern Europe

NORTHERN EUROPE (Vikings):

Materials:

- **Wool** - Dominant (cold climate)
 - Thick, felted for water resistance. Wadmal (dense wool cloth)
- **Linen** – Underlayers
 - Breathable, moisture management, comfortable on skin
- **Fur** - Essential for survival
 - Bear, wolf, fox, seal. Status through rarity
- **Leather** - Practical

Dyes:

Limited palette (harsh climate = fewer dye plants)

- Reds (madder), yellows (local plants), blues (woad)
- Natural undyed common



Then going to northern Europe, where the materials are recognisable from the medieval times

They used wool, linen, furs and leather, and all fabrics reflect the colder climate that they lives in.

Furs were essential for survival while also showing status through rarity

As these people lived in a harsher climate, they had limited dye plants available.

East Asia

EAST ASIA (Japan, China):

Materials:

- **Silk** - ABUNDANT (originated here)
 - Multiple weights and weaves. Brocade (woven patterns with gold/silver thread). Gossamer sheers to heavy ceremonial
- **Hemp/Ramie** - Common people. Coarse, practical, durable
- **Cotton** - Later period. Comfortable, practical

Dyes (Sophisticated techniques):

- **Indigo** - Deep blues (Japanese indigo dyeing = art form)
- **Safflower** - Reds/pinks
- **Natural mordants** - Create colour variations
- **Resist dyeing** (shibori, tie-dye) - Patterns through binding
- **Multiple dipping** - Layered colors



< Chinese ceremonial silk



Gossamer sheer silk



Resist dyeing



Silk is a big material for east Asia as the silk moth was abundant here. Often, asia would give western rulers silk as a diplomatic gift. At one point, there was so much silk available that in china and Japan even relatively ordinary people wore it.

Japanese indigo dyeing is worth a brief mention as it became such a refined art form that specific techniques like shibori developed into their own distinct aesthetic, which is still immediately recognisable today.

Why this matters for games

- **Cultural accuracy:** Greek characters in silk = wrong (too expensive)
- **Climate logic:** Desert tribe in heavy fur = doesn't make sense
- **Colour palette by culture:** Not all cultures had all colours



The three examples here are all about internal logic. Greek characters in silk, desert tribes in heavy fur, colour palettes that don't match the culture. These are the kinds of details that erode believability without players necessarily being able to name why.

The costume is doing background worldbuilding whether you intend it to or not. Getting the materials right means that background work is accurate.

Question for you

Greek clothing was draped and pinned, not sewn.

Japanese kimono are made from straight-line rectangles.

How is that different from the tailored, fitted construction we saw in medieval and Victorian periods?

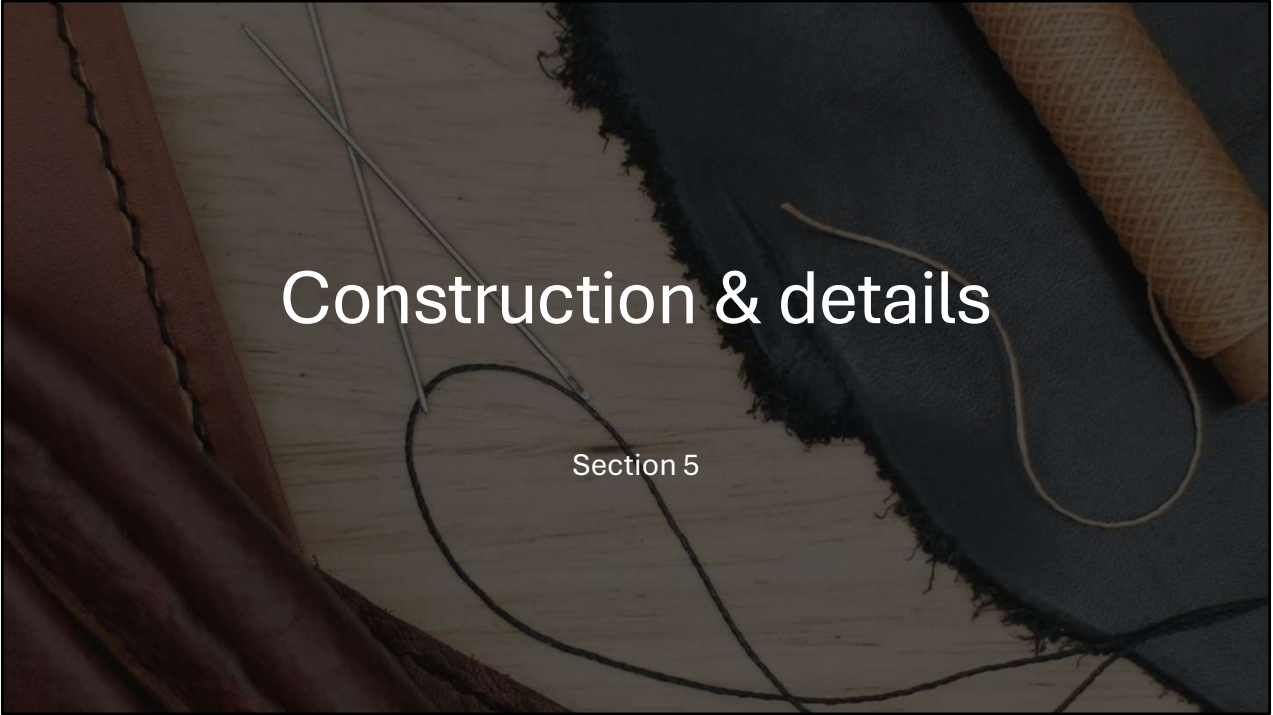
So another question for you

Greek clothing was draped and pinned, not sewn.

Japanese kimono are made from straight-line rectangles.

How is that different from the tailored, fitted construction we saw in medieval and Victorian periods?

Answer: The difference between draped/wrapped garments and tailored fitted clothing is massive — different pattern logic, different fabric behaviour, different movement properties. Let them think about it first before you explain it.



Construction & details

Section 5

Construction & details

Leather & hide

LEATHER/HIDE CONSTRUCTION:

VIKING/NORSE LEATHER WORKING:

Construction Methods:

- **Leather Lacing**
- Holes punched along edges
- Laced together with leather thongs

Stitching

- Sinew or leather thread
- Visible stitches (becomes decoration)
- Strong seams, minimal stretch

VIKING/NORSE



< Leather thong lacing



< Deer leg sinew

Leather doesn't work like fabric — you can't sew it the same way because you're working with a material that doesn't fray, doesn't stretch much, and holds its shape permanently once broken in.

Lacing along punched edges is a construction method that's both functional and immediately readable as a design language. With the visual stitching also becoming a decoration

Construction & details

Leather & hide

LEATHER/HIDE CONSTRUCTION:

VIKING/NORSE LEATHER WORKING:

Straps and Buckles

- Adjustable fastening
- Allows fit customisation

Leather Behaviour:

- Stiff when new
- Softens with wear (crease patterns develop)
- Holds shape (unlike fabric)
- Creases form at stress points, become permanent

VIKING/NORSE



^ example of leather wear

The wear behaviour of leather is genuinely useful for character design — a character who has worn the same leather armour for years will have very specific crease and wear patterns at the flex points.

Those patterns are a storytelling tool.

A brand new character has stiff, unbroken leather.

A veteran has permanent creases at the elbow, the knee, anywhere the joint creates repeated stress.

Construction & details

Tribal / indigenous

TRIBAL/INDIGENOUS CONSTRUCTION:

HIDE PREPARATION:

- Brain-tanning (creates soft leather)
- Smoke-curing (water-resistant, darker)
- Different stiffness depending on method

Construction Techniques:

- **Minimal Seams**
- Large pieces, few cuts
- Follows hide shape

Fringe

- Cut into hide edges
- Decorative AND functional (sheds water)

Animation: Moves freely, acts like hair

TRIBAL



The different ways a hide has been prepared creates different results, brain tanning makes the leather softer which smoke curing makes it water resistant and darker

A fringe cut into leather is an interesting example of functional decoration as it helps shed the water but its animation is different from normal fabric as it moves independently and acts like hair

Construction & details

Tribal / indigenous

TRIBAL/INDIGENOUS CONSTRUCTION:

Lacing

- Leather thongs through holes
- Adjustable, repairable

Layering for Warmth

- Fur worn hair-side-in (warmth)
- Leather worn hair-side-out (weather)

CLOSURE TYPES:

- Ties (leather thongs)
- Toggles (bone, wood)
- Wrapping (no fasteners)

Masaai tribe leather shield



Nutukas – Sámi boots



TRIBAL

Tribal cultures didn't have zippers, buttons or anything like that. They used ties, toggles or wrappings to close garments.

Construction & details

Wrapped & draped

WRAPPED/DRAPED CONSTRUCTION (No Sewing):

GREEK CHITON:

Construction:

- One large rectangle (150cm x 300cm typical)
- Folded over at top (creates overfold)
- Pinned at shoulders (fibulae pins)
- Belted at waist (optional)

Key Technical Points:

- Fabric GRAIN matters (drape follows grain)
- Pin placement affects drape
- Overfold creates double layer (heavier drape on upper body)
- Asymmetric draping = one side always has more fabric

GREEK

ANCIENT GREECE c. 480-450 BC



As you have learned in the hands-on textile workshop or the marvelous explanation of this morning, the direction of the fabric determines how it drapes. These garments are basically a study of how much you can do with a rectangle and a few pins. Move a pin and the fold shifts. It's a responsive system for something with no sewing involved

Construction & details

Wrapped & draped

WRAPPED/DRAPED CONSTRUCTION:

ROMAN TOGA:

Construction:

- Semicircle (can be 6m long arc)
- Complex wrapping technique (15+ steps)
- NO pins or fastenings (held by tension and gravity)

Key Technical Points:

- Specific draping over left shoulder
- Right arm free
- VERY heavy (3-5kg of fabric)
- Arm raising pulls entire drape
- Walking affects lower draping

ROMAN



[How to wear a toga instruction video](#) >



The toga is very impractical but that was the point. The whole thing is held together by the tension and weight of the fabric itself. Every movement changes the drape.

Getting dressed in a toga often required help and senators and officials wore togas to signal they didn't need to do anything physical.

Just as the big dresses in the Victorian types did, the garment communicates status through inconvenience and limit in movement

Intricate details *Roman jewellery*

- Wore a lot of jewellery
- Bracelets, necklace, tiara, rings, brooches
- Often snakes



ROMAN

. The jewellery of ancient romans was very much inspired by the Egyptian jewellery style
They wore a lot of gold and the most common shape was snakes here you can see some examples

Construction & details

Wrapped & draped

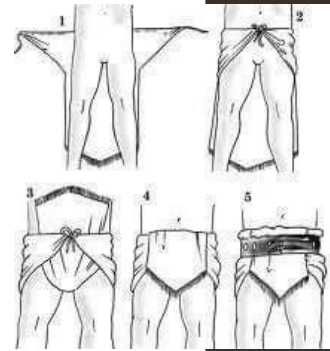
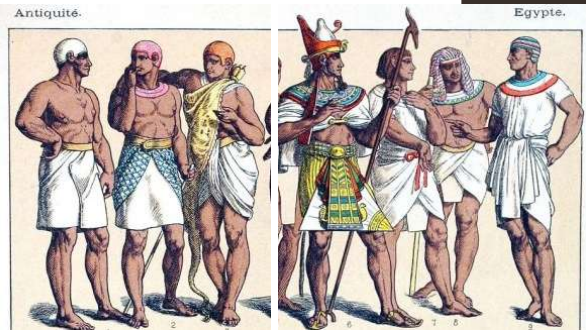
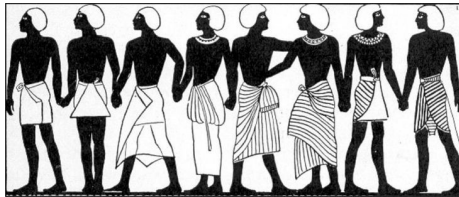
WRAPPED/DRAPED CONSTRUCTION (No Sewing)

EGYPTIAN SHENDYT/SCHENTI (Kilt):

- Rectangle wrapped around waist
- Pleated front panel (stiffened with starch)
- Tied or tucked

Animation:

- Pleats hold shape (rigid)
- Wrapped portion can shift
- Often walks stiffly to maintain pleats



EGYPTIAN

[Link](#) with a lot of Egyptian wrap garments + "patterns"

Pleating is an interesting part of Egyptian construction. They achieved pleating through starch and moisture which results in pleats that are semi permanent and quite rigid.

This also influences the animation, it would move a lot stiffer than a modern non starched pleated skirt would do

Construction & details

Wrapped & draped

WRAPPED/DRAPED CONSTRUCTION

(No Sewing)

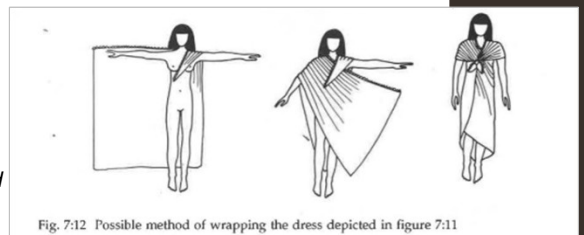
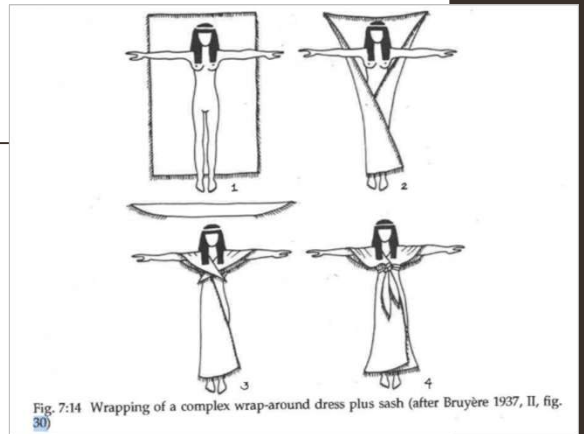
EGYPTIAN WRAP DRESS

- Rectangle wrapped around body
- Tied at torso
- Sometimes with belt or sash

Wrapping manner is flexible
Depending on status, time of day, tasks, etc.

[Link](#) book for lots of
Egyptian clothing and
wraps explained

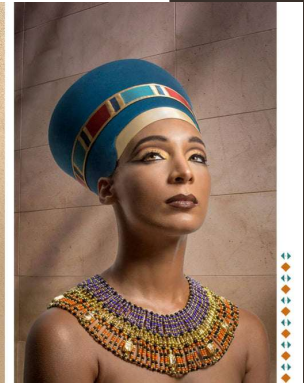
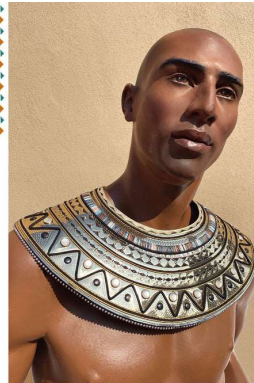
EGYPTIAN



It is worth noting that the orientation and location of where the rectangle started on the body could produce a very different silhouette. This might be interesting for character design because it means you can show the same character in different social or practical contexts just by changing the arrangement of the same garment.

Intricate details *Egyptian jewellery*

- Important part of culture
- Lower class wore copper, beads, imitation gemstones
- Often gold but silver was considered more precious
- Burial specific jewellery



EGYPTIAN

History source

Then jewellery in Egypt

Egypt is known for its intricate jewellery. As they wore plain [linen](#) clothes, jewellery was a means to enhance their beauty. they preferred gold jewellery, bright-colored stones, and precious metals. interestingly silver was rarely worn but it was considered more precious than gold.

Construction & details

Asian garments

ASIAN CROSS-COLLAR CONSTRUCTION:

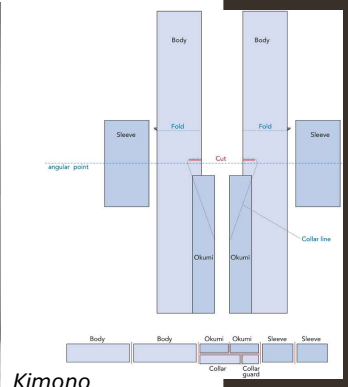
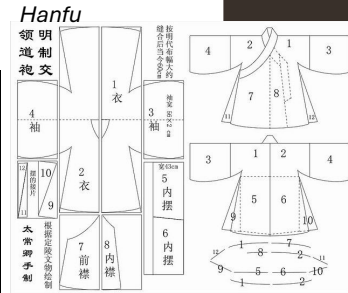
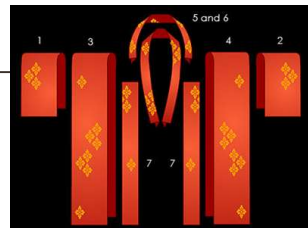
KIMONO/HANFU CONSTRUCTION:

- **Pattern Pieces:**
- All straight lines and rectangles
- Minimal cutting waste

Standard Pattern:

- Main body: 2 panels (front/back)
- Sleeves: 2 rectangles
- Collar: Long strip
- Overlap panel (mae-migoro)

ASIAN



Kimono

Interesting about kimono and Hanfu construction is all the straight lines and used almost all of the fabric available which limits cutting waste

Construction & details

Asian garments

Key Construction Elements: Overlap Closure

- Left over right (ALWAYS)
- Secured with obi/sash

Animation:

- Closure not sewn (can shift)
- Obi holds everything (tight compression at waist)
- Fabric loose above/below obi

Collar

- Stands away from neck (space between)
- Folds over at back

Animation:

- Collar maintains shape, doesn't collapse onto neck

ASIAN



Left over right — always. The opposite direction was reserved for dressing the dead.

This is the kind of cultural specificity that can come across as either respectful attention to detail or an obvious mistake, depending on whether you know it. The collar standing away from the neck is also a specific visual marker that's easy to get wrong, as you can see in the blue dress

Construction & details

Asian garments

Kimono >

Key Construction Elements: Sleeve Construction

- Deep armhole (sleeve opening)
- Rectangular sleeve hangs

Animation:

- Sleeve swings freely
- Large opening = arm moves independently inside



< Hanfu

ASIAN

The deep armhole means the arm moves largely independently of the sleeve. the sleeve isn't attached to the arm the way a fitted jacket is. It hangs, and it reacts to gravity and momentum rather than tracking the arm directly. That's a very different cloth sim setup than a fitted Western sleeve.

Construction & details

Asian garments

OBI (BELT) MECHANICS:

- Wound multiple times (very tight)
- Creates rigid cylinder at waist

Movement:

- Torso CANNOT bend at waist
- Bending happens above or below obi
- Walking = hip movement, upper body stays upright



ASIAN

The obi is basically a rigid cylinder at the waist and all movement happens above or below it as the wearer cannot bend at the waist
the deliberate, upright carriage of someone in formal kimono is partly cultural etiquette and partly just physics. You cannot slouch in a tight obi.

Construction & details

Asian armour construction

JAPANESE ARMOUR (O-YOROI/DO):

Laced Plate Construction:

- Small plates (kozane)
- Laced together with silk cords
- Creates flexible armoured surface



Animation:

- Individual plates can move
- Lacing provides flex between plates
- Large shoulder guards (sode) swing independently
- Layered construction = complex movement



The six major components are the dō (cuirass), kabuto (helmet), menpo (mask), kote (armoured sleeves), suneate (greaves), and the hai-date (cuisses).

ASIAN

[O-yoroi with patterns](#)

[O-yoroi Wikipedia](#)

The laced plate system of Japanese armour is very cool engineering
The individual plates laced together with cords creates something protective yet also flexible.
It allows the plates to shift relative to each other
It is complex to animate but the visual result reads clearly as Japanese armour rather than generic armour

Why this matters for games & animation

DRAPED GARMENTS:

- Anchor points (pins, belt) = where fabric hangs from
- No seams = fabric can shift position
- Heavy fabric = affected by gravity and momentum
- Asymmetric draping = uneven weight distribution

FLAT-PATTERN CONSTRUCTION:

- Straight seams = predictable fold lines
- Rectangular sleeves = swing freely
- Tight belt = rigid waist (no bending)

LEATHER/HIDE:

- Holds shape (doesn't drape like fabric)
- Creases develop at flex points
- Fringe moves independently



The key phrase here is "anchor points."

In draped garments, the anchor points are pins and belts. Everything hangs from those.

In flat-pattern construction, the seams are predictable fold lines.

In leather, the flex points are where permanent creases develop.

Knowing your anchor points is how you set up cloth simulation and sculpt believable folds.

Question for you

When **you** are designing a character with wings or horns or a tail, how do you think clothing would adapt to those features?

Would all cultures solve it the same way?

Another question for you, When **you** are designing a character with wings or horns or a tail, how do you think clothing would adapt to those features?
Would all cultures solve it the same way?

Answer A Greek character with wings would probably have a draped solution, something pinned and open at the back.

A Japanese character with wings would have a very different structural problem to solve given that the kimono is a back panel.

Different construction logic leads to different adaptations.



That was all the period and cultural theory, its finally time for the special topic:
creature adapted clothing

Special topic introduction

Why it fits: Mythology = creatures with non-human features

Content:

- Horns: Hood/helmet accommodations, how fabric drapes around them
- Wings: Back openings (slits, lacing, wraps), how different cultures might solve this
- Tails: Openings in skirts/trousers, different tail types need different solutions
- Multiple arms: Sleeve configurations
- Digitigrade legs: Trouser/boot modifications

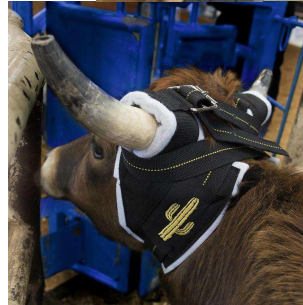
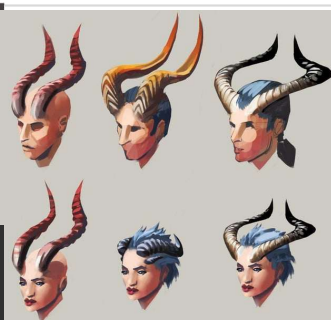


The reason this fits into the Ancient/Cultural session specifically is that this period is full of mythology — and mythology is full of non-human figures who, in game contexts, need actual clothing.

This section is about treating that as a real design problem rather than a stylistic choice.

Horns

Horns: Hood/helmet accommodations, how fabric drapes around them



Think about:

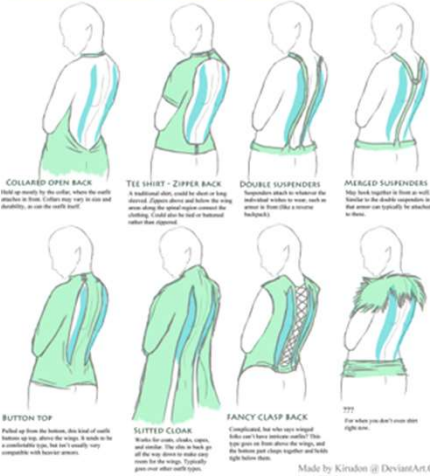
- Neck/head opening
- Edge finishing
- Hoods for horns have different balance
- Hide, frame, decorate horns

Wings

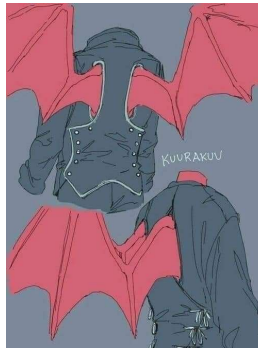
Outfits for Winged Folks - A Back Study

Some days it seems more people who draw winged humanoid don't take into account these very same wings in their characters' outfit choices. This mostly goes for people in some groups who want more frequent ideas on clothing designs for avians. Sometimes, birds and things can vary, but make sure it makes sense! Take into account the size and shape of the wings, and the way your character will put on the outfit. No outfit with a button closure if there's no way to get the wings through!

This guide works for dragons, angels, or whatever other winged humanoid you like to draw. Feel free to use it!



Made by Kirukon @ DeviantArt.Com
May 2015



Think about:

- Back panel redesign
- Range of motion
- Closure location
- Being able to dress yourself
- Edge finishing around wing roots
- Layering complexity



Tails

Tails: Openings in skirts/trousers, different tail types need different solutions

Design for:

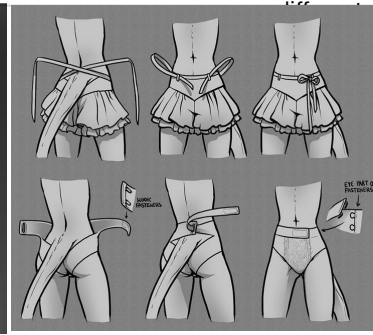
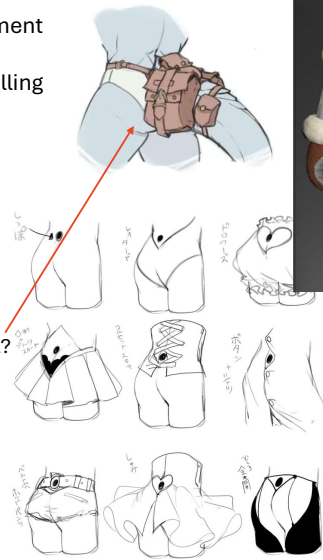
- Freedom of tail movement
- Protection/coverage
- Social/aesthetic signalling

Pants with:

- Tail corsetry
- Tail port
- Tail gusset
- Tail covers or sleeves
- Tail ornaments
- Concealed? Exposed?
- Skirts/robes
- Additional pockets on tail?

Keep in mind:

- Fabric ride-up
- Seated accommodation
- Waistband adjustment

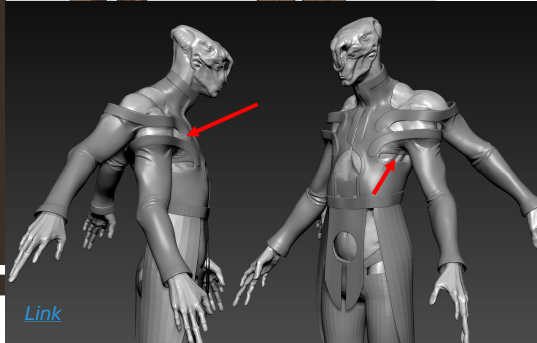


Maybe tail-allowing breeches?

[Quora](#) discussion about tail clothing

[Reddit](#) discussion about tail adaptations

Extra arms



[Link](#)

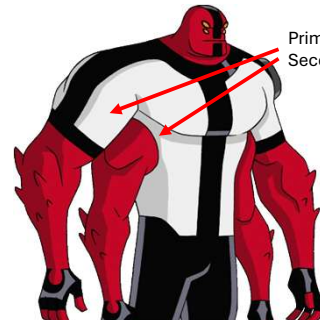
Instagram user viffrey



Think of:

- Armhole placement
- Dressing logistics
- Ease of movement
- Primary/secondary arm set?
- Sleeve volume, length, decoration

DC comics Salakk



Primary
Secondary

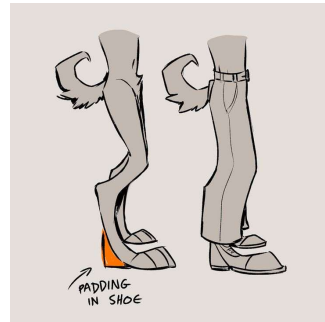
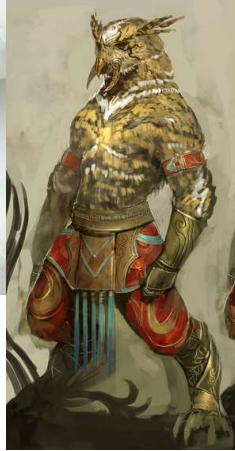
Digitigrade legs

Digitigrade legs: Trouser/boot modifications



Think of:

- Leg pattern might be closer to suit "bend" arm pattern than human-trousers
- Knee/hock joint allowance (gusset, stretchy fabric)
- Where does footwear end/begin?
- Might not be able to pull on pants like we do because of the curves. Side seam zippers? Buttons?
- Waistband placement, trouser rise needs adjustment



Game application

- Fantasy races, alien species, monster design
- Difference between a costume that looks like it was painted on vs one that looks like it could exist.
 - Solve it in your concept
 - Doesn't become someone else's guesswork
 - Make the pipeline easier
 - Make the character more believable
- What would a tailor in this world make for someone with horns, given these materials and this culture's technology?



A costume that looks like it was painted on a character with no thought for how it functions reads as a costume.

A costume with visible solutions to actual construction problems reads as clothing.

That difference is what makes characters feel like they inhabit a world rather than being dressed for one.

The question at the bottom is a good one to internalise: what would a tailor in this world actually make for this body?



Discussion & reflection

Section 7

Reflection prompt

We covered diverse construction methods today (draped, flat-pattern, wrapped).

Choose ONE method that was new to you:

- What surprised you about this construction method?
- How is it different from European tailored clothing?
- Can you think of a game scenario where this knowledge would be useful? (e.g., *designing a specific culture, understanding how fabric behaves differently, etc.*)"

Construction methods:

- Draping
- Wrapping
- Tied / laced
- Flat patterns
- Layering
- Creature adapted clothing

Next guild:

- Modern to cyberpunk/sci-fi
- 1900s – Future >

When there's no historical reference, how do you design believable clothing?



The next and final guild will be about modern to cyberpunk and sci fi
This starts at roughly 1900s and extends into the far future

More interesting sources

Tribal/stone-age

Stunning recreation of Stone Age woman [\[link\]](#)

Stone age jewellery [\[link\]](#)

Visit the open-air museum Archeon ☺ [\[link\]](#)

Northern European

Ancient crafts: Medieval/viking leatherworking [\[link\]](#)

Viking textile dying with plants [\[link\]](#)

Blog with a bunch of Viking jewellery recreations [\[link\]](#)

Mediterranean

Ancient Greek and Roman wrapped garments – FIT fashion history [\[link\]](#)

Fashion and jewellery of ancient Egypt [\[link\]](#)

Ancient Greek costumes explained + “patterns” [\[link\]](#) < very in-depth

Book Pharaonic Egyptian Clothing [\[link\]](#)

Roman clothing items described [\[link\]](#)

More interesting sources

Asian

Japan

Japanese fashion throughout the years [\[link\]](#)

A short history of kimono [\[link\]](#)

Class identity in feudal Japan [\[link\]](#)

Medieval Japanese clothing – Big list of sources [\[link\]](#)

Kyoto costume institute - archive of historical clothing [\[link\]](#)

Medieval Japan historical clothing blog – armor and clothing manuals [\[link\]](#)

Kimono sewing YouTube tutorial playlist [\[link\]](#)

China

Intro to traditional Chinese clothing [\[link\]](#)

China silk museum – online archive pieces [\[link\]](#)

Chinese museum pieces – MET museum [\[link\]](#)

Korea

Korean museum pieces – MET museum [\[link\]](#)

Traditional Korean costumes and textiles – museum pieces (images) [\[link\]](#)

Korean gallery of clothing – Daegu National Museum [\[link\]](#)